



115 Game on



118 Digit's Believe It Or Not!



132 Pink... For Posh?

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Touched By Tech

Sight And Sound

The visually impaired rely on hearing and touch to learn, work, and play. Enhancing their abilities is a software called JAWS

Jyotsna Rege

Artificial limbs. Cochlear implants. Pacemakers. People with disabilities have benefited tremendously from these marvels of technology. But entire eye transplants apart, a cure for blindness still seems far away. So how is society to help the blind lead lives that could be considered "normal"?

Most learning happens via association. As children, we see a fruit red in colour and round as an orb, and we hear "apple." The next time we see the object, the mind connects the image to the word—now etched in our memory—and we know it is an apple. Association, however, is not limited to the sense of sight: the visually handicapped use touch and hearing to discern, make associations, and learn.

Using Their Ears

One way of empowering the blind is to teach them to use computers: this not only enriches their lives, it also helps them gain employment. A piece of software is bringing light to thousands of lives: called JAWS, it is a screen reader, and is used by most training centres for the

visually handicapped all over the country.

Upon first thought, it sounds incredible that the blind can be taught to use computers. The concept is simple, however: have the software read out everything on the screen. JAWS does just that: everything that is typed—word for word, letter for letter—it reads it all out and helps the user understand what they've just done and what actions are available.

Effective Empowerment

The MN Banaji Institute at Mumbai for the Blind is one of the institutes that teach basic courses in computers. The visually handicapped here have long been trained in various industries such as weaving and stitching so they can work to support themselves financially, but it is only recently that an institute for the blind has been opened to instruct them in the use of computers. "To learn and be a part of the social world is a human need. Besides, the use of computers is so wide-

spread that to not know how to use them is a big impediment to gaining employment. The institute therefore hopes that the ability to use computers with the help of JAWS will make a difference in gaining employment for the students," says Vikas Joseph, head of the Institute.

The courses are of a six-month duration. Tanya Balsara, who herself learnt computing with the help of JAWS, teaches the courses and conducts the examinations as well. The students are anywhere between 18 and 45 years old. Balsara says, "It's a pleasure to teach them. Because of my own disability, I personally understand their confusion in not comprehending a particular detail, so I can take added care to explain features and tasks."

Imaging: Pradip Ingale
Photograph: Sandeep Patil

